elections and serve the people if they are able to get the mandate? The fact is peace and progress don't suit them or fit into their scheme of things. The outsiders are imposing on you a way of life that goes against the grain of your culture. As written by one of your ilk in the letter that was just read out, they are misleading everyone. Whatever customs and practices they are forcing on you and your womenfolk in Kashmir, why aren't they being insisted upon in Karachi, Lahore or Islamabad?

Muslims who chose to migrate to Pakistan at the time of Partition stand permanently branded – they are referred to as 'mohajirs' [refugees] even today. Did they make a mistake? In comparison, my grandparents and their entire clan of Khatri Punjabis left their lands and property in Rawalpindi, Lahore, or Gujaranwala areas, and migrated to India. My father was a lieutenant colonel, and I have risen to the rank of a brigadier. Likewise, all others have resurrected themselves admirably. We are proud Indians, and no one refers to us as refugees.

Take the case of the Bihari Muslims who sided with the Pakistan Army and even laid down their lives during the Indo-Pak war of 1971, when Bangladesh was created. They were given assurances that they would be resettled in Pakistan. They are having a miserable existence in camps in Bangladesh even today, as Pakistan has been unable to give them a place to resettle in. Weren't they loyal and good Muslims?

You must, therefore, neither entertain any wrong notions nor be under false illusions. Pakistan will continue to do its best to keep the fire simmering in Kashmir. Don't get taken for a ride any longer, my wise Kashmiri brothers. It is time for you to say enough is enough!

This is the manner in which I used to interact with the villagers, and convey my ideas as the brigade commander to the mostly ignorant populace – the suffering poor of the valley. In the meanwhile, my units and sub units would complete their assigned operational tasks and thereafter, we would return to our base.

The 15 Corps commander, Lieutenant General Zaki's assessment in 1991 that there was large-scale infiltration taking place in the north Jhelum sector, the corridor between the Shamsabari and the Jhelum river – was proved right by the phenomenal successes my units began to achieve. The previous brigade commander had claimed that not even a bird could get through his sector undetected and